

2c. Content of religious Beliefs and teachings & Practices (J625/01-05)

Introduction to Component Group 1

In this component, learners have the opportunity to study key concepts within their two chosen religions in order to develop knowledge and understanding of the basis of the religions' beliefs, teachings and practices.

As part of the study, learners will recognise and consider the existence and importance of common and divergent views within their chosen religions' traditions, in the way beliefs, teachings and practices are understood and expressed.

They will acquire knowledge and understanding of sources of authority and wisdom that underpin and connect teachings, beliefs and practices and be able to refer to them in responses. Learners will explore how their chosen religions influence individuals, communities and societies.

Learners will also have the opportunity to develop their ability to explain, analyse and evaluate topics, in order to offer reasoned and supported arguments in discussions about key issues within your chosen religions.

The spelling of words which have been transliterated from non-Roman alphabets will be used consistently through the assessment materials. Learners will not be penalised for the use of other common spellings.

For Buddhism and Hinduism, learners should be aware that suggested sources of wisdom and authority are examples of references to core Buddhist/Hindu concepts made within Buddhist/Hindu writings. Modern understandings of these concepts are constructed from multiple sources and tradition, rather than being based on a single text.

Beliefs and teachings

Learners should be able to:

- demonstrate knowledge and understanding of the area of study and its importance for their chosen religions' belief, teaching and practice
- analyse, evaluate and discuss the issues raised by the area of study and their importance for individuals, communities and societies in your chosen religions
- include any relevant sources of wisdom and authority, including scripture and/or sacred texts where appropriate
- consider significant common and divergent views within your chosen religions.

Practices

Learners should be able to:

- demonstrate knowledge and understanding of your chosen religions' practices and their importance for individuals, communities and societies
- analyse, evaluate and discuss the issues surrounding your chosen religions' practices
- reference any relevant sources of wisdom and authority, including scripture and/or sacred texts where appropriate
- consider significant common and divergent views about your chosen religions' practices

Christianity

Beliefs and teachings & Practices (J625/01)

Learners will need to be familiar with the expectations laid out on page 6 of the specification.

Beliefs and teachings		
Area of study	Content	Suggested sources of wisdom and authority
	Learners should have studied the following:	(Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate sources of wisdom and authority unless stated otherwise)
Nature of God	• The meaning of the terms: ◦ benevolent ◦ omniscient ◦ omnipotent ◦ monotheistic ◦ judge ◦ eternal ◦ transcendent ◦ immanent ◦ personal ◦ forgiving • The significance for Christians of these characteristics: ◦ benevolent ◦ omniscient ◦ omnipotent ◦ monotheistic ◦ judge ◦ eternal ◦ transcendent ◦ immanent ◦ personal ◦ forgiving • The common and divergent emphases placed on these characteristics (benevolent, omniscient, omnipotent, monotheistic, judge, eternal, transcendent, immanent, personal, forgiving) by different Christian denominations • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	• The Lord's Prayer Matthew 6:9–15 • The Ten Commandments (with reference to the first four commandments) • Exodus 20 • The Parable of the Lost (Prodigal) Son Luke 15:11–32 • John 3:16–18 • Matthew 25: 31–46

Concept of God as a Trinity of persons	• The concept of the Trinity as one God, three persons (Father, Son, Holy Spirit) • The relationship between Father, Son and Holy Spirit • Issues related to the Nature of God • Different attitudes to God as a Trinity • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	• Matthew 5:48 • John 14:16–17 • Phillipians 2:5–8 • The Apostles' Creed • The Nicene Creed • Unitarian Churches e.g. Christadelphians
Biblical accounts of Creation	• The concept of God as creator • The role of God the Father as creator in the Genesis narrative • The role of the Spirit in Genesis 1–2, as the agent of God • The role of the Word in John 1 • The identification of Jesus in John's Gospel chapter 1 as the Word of God linking him to creation and his pre-existence • The role and purpose of human beings • The Fall in the Genesis narrative • Issues raised in Genesis for different Christian groups, literal interpretations and metaphorical understandings • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	Learners must study: • Genesis 1–3 • John 1 Other suggested sources of wisdom and authority: • The Apostles' Creed • Romans 1:20
The problem of evil and suffering and a loving and righteous God	• Concepts of evil • Different types of evil: natural evil and moral evil • Causes of evil • The Fall of mankind as the result of Free Will • The concept of original sin • The concept of Good • The problem of the existence of evil and suffering: how an all-powerful (omnipotent) God can allow evil and suffering if he is also loving (benevolent) and righteous • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	Learners must study: • Genesis 3:1–19 Other suggested sources of wisdom and authority: • The Lord's Prayer • The message contained in the Book of Job

Jesus Christ	• The meaning of the terms: Messiah, Son of God, Lord and Saviour • The significance for Christians of the titles Messiah, Son of God, Lord and Saviour as descriptions of Jesus • The relevance of Messiah, Son of God, Lord and Saviour as descriptions of Jesus for Christians today • The role and importance of Jesus' teachings and life as an example for Christians • Christian love (agape) • The Christian ideal as expressed in Jesus' teaching in the Sermon on the Mount • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	• The Ten Commandments • The Two Great Commandments Matthew 22:36–39 • The Parable of the Good Samaritan Luke 10:25–37 • The Apostles' Creed • The Nicene Creed • Jesus' healing miracles as examples of agape: Matthew 8:1–3, Mark 5:21–42 • Matthew 5–7
Incarnation, Crucifixion, Resurrection and Ascension	• The meaning of the terms: the incarnation, the crucifixion, the resurrection and the ascension • Beliefs and teachings about Jesus arising from the incarnation, the crucifixion, the resurrection and the ascension • The importance to Christians of the incarnation, the crucifixion, the resurrection and the ascension for their life and worship • The common and divergent emphases placed on the significance of the incarnation, the crucifixion, the resurrection and the ascension for the beliefs of different Christian denominations • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	• Luke 1:26–35 • Mark 15:21–41 • Matthew 28:1–10 • Acts 1:9–11 • The Apostles' Creed • The Nicene Creed
The concept of salvation	• The meaning of the following terms: ◦ Salvation – restoring the relationship between God and mankind ◦ Atonement – God in Christ reconciles the world to himself ◦ Law – its function to identify sin by laying down commandments ◦ Sin – Pauline views, all have sinned and fallen short of the mark ◦ Grace – God's redemptive love to save sinners ◦ Spirit – The Holy Spirit • The role of Christ in salvation: the sacrifice of Christ – paying the ransom to God for the sins of the world	• Genesis 3:1–7 • Nicene Creed • Romans 3:23 • Romans 6:23 • 1 Corinthians • Ephesians 2:8–9 • Romans 3:24 • The Apostles' Creed

	• Issues related to salvation: the belief in forgiveness and repentance for all • The nature of atonement for Christians • Common and divergent Christian beliefs about the need for salvation • Common and divergent Christian beliefs about the role of Jesus Christ in salvation • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	
Eschatological beliefs and teachings	• The meaning of the terms resurrection, life after death, heaven and hell • Apocalyptic ideas in the Early Church • Common and divergent beliefs about the Second Coming of Christ (Parousia) • Common and divergent beliefs about, and interpretations of, death, judgement, purgatory, heaven and hell • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	• The Apostles' Creed • The Nicene Creed • Matthew 25:31–46 • Matthew 5:29–30 • 1 Corinthians 15:12–58 • John 14:1–3

Practices		
Area of study	Content	Suggested sources of wisdom and authority
	Learners should have studied the following:	(Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate sources of wisdom and authority)
Worship	• The structure of church services, for example Anglican Communion service, Roman Catholic mass, Quaker meeting, Greek Orthodox service and Methodist Sunday morning worship • The concept of worship • Purposes of worship • The role and importance of liturgical worship for some Christians • The role and importance of informal/charismatic worship for some Christians • The role and importance of individual prayer, private prayer and devotion for Christians • The role and importance of private and public worship to Christian communities and individuals • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	• Denominational service prayer books • John 4:24 • Romans 8:14 • Remembrance Services: Matthew 18:20
Sacraments	• The meaning of the word sacrament • The role and meaning of the sacraments • The role of Baptism and Eucharist in the life of a Christian • Common and divergent attitudes towards the practice and meaning of Baptism by different Christian denominations • Common and divergent attitudes towards the practice and meaning of the Eucharist by different Christian denominations • Common and divergent attitudes towards the Sacraments, including which practices are considered by different Christian denominations to be a sacrament • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	• Matthew 26:26–28 • Matthew 3:13–17 • 1 Corinthians 11:23–26

Prayer	• The concept of prayer • The impact and importance of prayer to a Christian • The importance of prayer in worship • The meaning and use of the Lord's Prayer (in both individual and communal worship) • The different types and uses of prayer in worship for individuals and communities including adoration, confession, thanksgiving, supplications, grace, intercessions, 'praying in the spirit', chants and meditational prayers • Common and divergent emphases placed on prayer by different Christian denominations, for example informal extempore prayer as compared to set liturgical prayer • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	• Different denominational service prayer books • Luke 11:1–4 • Matthew 6:5–15 • 1 Corinthians 14:26–40
The role and importance of pilgrimage and celebrations to Christians	• The concept of pilgrimage • The purpose of pilgrimage to Lourdes, Jerusalem, Walsingham and Rome • The impact of pilgrimage on individuals and for communities • The origin of Christmas and Easter • The impact and importance of Advent and Christmas celebrations to Christians • The impact and importance of Lent, Holy Week and Easter celebrations to Christians • Common and divergent attitudes towards the importance of pilgrimages by different Christian denominations • Common and divergent attitudes towards the role and importance of celebrations by different Christian denominations • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	• Luke 2:1–20 • Matthew 2:1–12 • Matthew 26:17–29 • Matthew 27:45–55 • Matthew 28:1–10
The role of the church in the local community and living practices	• The meaning and importance of rites of passage • The importance of Christian rituals that mark key rites of passage to individuals and communities • The ways in which church communities nurture and support families, for example Sunday schools, youth clubs, mother and child groups, visiting the elderly and the sick • Common and divergent attitudes of different Christian denominations towards and practices connected with membership of the Christian community, including infant baptism, dedication, believers baptism and confirmation	• Matthew 3:13–17 • Ephesians 5:31–33 • John 11:25 • 1 Corinthians 15:51

	• Common and divergent attitudes of different Christian denominations towards and practices connected with the celebration of marriage • Common and divergent attitudes of different Christian denominations towards and practices connected with funerals • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	
Mission	• The meaning of the term mission • The importance of mission in the modern church • Common and divergent attitudes towards the importance of mission for Christians in 21st century Britain by different Christian denominations • The meaning of the term evangelism • Common and divergent attitudes towards the importance of evangelism in the modern church by different Christian denominations • Evangelism in practice • The growth of new forms of church • Reasons for the growth of new forms of church • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	• Matthew 28:16–20 • Mark 16:15 • John 14:6 • Romans 1:16 • Timothy 4:2 • Acts 1:8
The role of the church in the wider world	• The meaning of the term Ecumenical • The meaning of the word Church (spiritual and temporal) and of churches as individual communities • The main purpose of the World Council of Churches, including reconciliation through ecumenism • The work of ecumenical communities, for example: Taizé, Iona, Corrymeela and the 'Churches Together' movement • The way in which the Church is being persecuted in the 21st century • Supporting the persecuted church • The purpose of one of the following Christian aid agencies: ◦ Christian Aid ◦ Tearfund ◦ Cafod • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Christian denominations	• John 13:34–35 • Mark 12:31 • Matthew 25:31–46

Beliefs and teachings & Practices (J625/02)

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Beliefs and teachings		
Area of study	Content	Suggested sources of wisdom and authority
	Learners should have studied the following:	(Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate sources of wisdom and authority)
Core beliefs	- Articles of faith - The six articles of faith in Sunni Islam: - Belief in Allah as the one and only God - Belief in angels - Belief in holy books - Belief in the Prophets - Belief in the Day of Judgement - Belief in Predestination - The overall importance of the six articles of belief for Sunni Muslims - The meaning of 'Usul ad-Din' (The Principles of Faith) - The five roots of 'Usul ad-Din' in Shi'a Islam: - Belief in Oneness and Unity of God (Al-Tawhid) - Belief in Divine Justice (Al-Adl) - Belief in Prophethood (Al-Nubuwwah) - Belief in Imams (Al-Imamah) - Belief in the Day of Resurrection (Al-Ma'ad) - The overall importance of the five roots 'Usul ad-Din' for Shi'ite Muslims - Issues related to core beliefs in Sunni Islam and Shi'a Islam - Belief about justice and imamate (leadership) which differentiates Shi'a Islam from Sunni Islam - Common and divergent attitudes of different groups of Muslims towards core beliefs - Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	- Six articles of faith in Sunni Islam - Surah 4:136 - Hadith from Sahih Muslim Book 33 Hadith 6400 (Qadr) - Five roots of Islam in Shi'a Islam - Surah 6:103 - Surah 23:62 (Adalah) - Surah 41:46 (Adalah) - Surah 16:36 (Al-Nubuwwah) - Surah 62:2 (Al-Nubuwwah) - Surah 57:25 (Al-Nubuwwah) - Surah 2:213 (Al-Nubuwwah) - Surah 4:59 (Imamah) - Surah 21:73 (Imamah) - Hadith al-Thaqalayn - Surah 74:38–40 (al-Ma'ad) - Surah 21:104

Nature of Allah	• The importance for Muslims of the 99 names of Allah with specific knowledge and understanding of: ◦ Tawhid (oneness) ◦ Merciful ◦ Omnipotent ◦ Benevolent ◦ Fair and Just ◦ Transcendent ◦ Immanent • The meaning of Tawhid and its relationship to the concept of shirk • The implications of Tawhid and shirk for polytheism and Christianity • Issues related to the Nature of Allah and how these attributes are shown: ◦ Allah's role as creator and judge demonstrate His omnipotence ◦ His concern with humankind and intervention as evidence of immanence ◦ His guidance to humankind showing His merciful nature • The Shi'a concept of the Imamate and its relationship to Shi'a belief in Tawhid • Common and divergent attitudes of different groups of Muslims towards the nature of Allah • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	• Surah 1 (al-Fatihah) • Surah 2:117 (al-Baqarah) • Surah 50:16 (Qaf) • Surah 53:19–25 (an-Najm) • Surah 112 (al-Ikhlās)
Prophethood (Risalah)	• The role and importance of the prophets: ◦ Adam as Allah's first creation. Created from clay, made in Allah's image, given the ability to reason and make choices and as khalifa ◦ Ibrahim as the father of the Arab people and of the prophets. He was a hanif. How Allah tested his devotion ◦ Isma'il as the first son of Ibrahim and connected with the building of the Kaaba ◦ Musa who was given the 10 commandments ◦ Dawud as receiving the Zabur and the story of his victory over Goliath ◦ The prophet Isa as not divine but chosen to deliver a message like the other prophets. His significance in the Qur'an and his role on the Day of Judgement	• Surah 3:31 • Surah 3:144 (al-Imran) • Surah 21:105 (al-Anbiya) • Surah 5:78 (al-Ma'idah) • Surah 46:9 (al-Ahqaf) • Surah 73:15

	◦ Muhammad (PBUH) as 'seal of the prophets' and the implications of this. His background and the personal qualities that made him a good prophet • Common and divergent attitudes of different groups of Muslims towards the role and importance of the prophets • Risalah as Allah's way of communicating with humans • The belief in the twelve Imams and their infallible nature (imamate) in Shi'a Islam • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	
Books (Kutub)	• Islam as the original religion dating back to Adam • The Scrolls (Sahifah), Gospel (Injil), Torah (Tawrat) and Psalms (Zabur) as revealed to four previous messengers • The original belief system was the same for all but became distorted • The Qur'an as the final undistorted message • Common and divergent attitudes of different groups of Muslims towards books (Kutub) and ancient texts • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	• Surah 96 (al-Alaq) • Surah 5:46 (al-Ma'idah) • Surah 5:48 (Wahy) • Surah 4:163 (an-Nisa)
Angels (Malaikah)	• The role and importance for Muslims of Jibril, Izra'il, Mika'il and Israfil: ◦ Jibril as chief angel communicating message between Allah and the rasul ◦ Izra'il taking the final breath from people ◦ Mika'il the guardian of heaven and bringer of thunder, who rewards the righteous ◦ Israfil blowing the trumpet on the Day of Judgement • Angels as Allah's first creation: immortal, free of sin and without free will • The role of angels as a primary source of communication between Allah and humankind • The way in which belief in recording angels may affect the behaviour of Muslims in daily life • Common and divergent attitudes of different groups of Muslims towards importance of angels • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	• Surah 16:102 (Malaikah) • Surah 35:1 (Fatir) • Surah 74:31 (al-Muddaththir)

Eschatological beliefs and teachings	• Predestination (al-Qad'r) as a divine masterplan • The idea of sifat (Allah's foreknowledge) and free will for humans • Human freedom and its relationship to the Day of Judgement • Knowledge of faith and action is recorded in each individual's book of life and read out on the Day of Judgement • Common and divergent attitudes of different groups of Muslims towards eschatological beliefs and teachings • Common and divergent attitudes towards the issue of human freedom in Sunni Islam and Shi'a Islam: Mu'tazilite and Al-Ashari • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	• Surah 12:42 (Yusuf) • Surah 33:38 (al-Ahzab)
Life after death (Akhirah)	• The meaning of the term Akhirah • Life as preparation for the life to come, after the Day of Judgement • The role of human responsibility and accountability in deciding the nature of the life to come, after the Day of Judgement • The Islamic concept of stewardship • Barzakh as the period between death and the Day of Judgement • Descriptions of heaven (al-Jannah) and hell (Jahannam) • Common and divergent attitudes of different groups of Muslims towards Akhirah • Literal and metaphorical interpretations of heaven and hell • The issue of martyrdom • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	• Surah 2:155 (al-Baqarah) • Surah 17:49–51 (al-'Isra) • Surah 101 (Yawm al Qiyyamah)

Practices		
Area of study	Content	Suggested sources of wisdom and authority
	Learners should have studied the following:	(Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate sources of wisdom and authority)
The importance of practices	- Islam as a way of life, lived in total submission to Allah - The importance of the Five Pillars of Islam to Sunni Muslims - The meaning of the Five Pillars: - Shahadah: sincerely reciting the Muslim profession of faith - Salat: performing ritual prayers in the proper way five times each day - Zakat/Zakah: paying an alms (or charity) tax to benefit the poor and the needy - Sawm: fasting during the month of Ramadan - Hajj: pilgrimage to Mecca - The analogy of the house and pillars - The importance of the Ten Obligatory Acts to Shi'a Muslims - The meaning of the Ten Obligatory Acts: - Salat Prayer - Sawm: Fast - Zakat/Zakah: similar to Sunni Islam, it applies to money - Khums: an annual taxation of one-fifth of gains in a year - Hajj: Pilgrimage - Jihad: Struggle - Amr-bil-Marooif: commanding what is good - Nahi Anil: Munkar forbid what is evil - Tawalla: expressing love towards good - Tabarra: expressing disassociation from evil - Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	- Shahadah: www.bbc.co.uk/religion/religions/islam/practices/shahadah.shtml http://www.oxforddictionaries.com/definition/english/shahada - Salat: http://www.bbc.co.uk/education/clips/z36cd2p - Zakat (Zakah): http://www.bbc.co.uk/religion/religions/islam/practices/zakat.shtml http://www.bbc.co.uk/education/clips/zrsd2hv - Sawm: http://www.bbc.co.uk/education/clips/zw37tfr - Hajj: http://www.bbc.co.uk/education/clips/zx8n34j - Jihad: http://www.bbc.co.uk/education/clips/z3xr87h

Public acts of worship	• How and why Muslims pray, ablution, times, directions, movements and recitations, in the home, mosque and elsewhere • Worship as a reminder of the concepts of Shirk and Tawhid • The purpose of congregational prayers • The purpose of the khutba • The place of Shahadah in Muslim practice, including the first words uttered to a newborn, for converting to the faith and said by/to the dying • Shahadah as the only 'non-action' pillar • The declaration <i>lā 'ilāha 'illā-llāh, muḥammadur-rasūlu-llāh</i> <i>There is no god but God. Muhammad is the messenger of God</i> • Salah as direct communication with Allah • Who has to attend Jummah prayers • Wudu ritual in detail, and the importance to Muslims of being spiritually and physically clean • The meaning of niyyah, qibla and raka't • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	• Surah 1 Al-Fatihah • Surah 4:103 (an-Nisa) • Surah 62:10 (al-Jumuah)
Private acts of worship	• The meaning of the term du'a (personal prayer or supplication, calling upon Allah) • The importance of private acts of worship to Muslims • The difference between du'a prayers and salah • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	• Surah 2:186 (al-Baqara)
Hajj	• The importance of pilgrimage for Muslims • Hajj as the obligatory pilgrimage • The origins of the pilgrimage • How and why the pilgrimage is performed • The exceptions to Hajj: if a Muslim is mentally/physically unfit or has insufficient funds • Ihram regulations • The rituals of Hajj and their significant for pilgrims whilst on pilgrimage and for their life • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	• Surah 22:26–38 (al-Hajj)

Zakat/Zakah	• The meaning of the terms Zakah and Khums • The role and importance of giving alms: the origins of the practice, how alms should be given, why Alms should be given, the benefits of giving Alms and Khums as an additional form of giving (Shi'a) • The Muslim attitude towards wealth as given by Allah and that it should be shared with those who need it • Sadaqah as voluntary alms • The idea of Nisab: 2.5% as the general amount given by most Muslims in the West • The distribution of alms • How Khums and Zakat/Zakah are separate and how they are apportioned • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	• Surah 2:215 (al-Baqarah) • Surah 9:60 (at-Tawbah)
Sawm	• The role and importance for Muslims of fasting in the month of Ramadan: ◦ the origins of fasting ◦ fasting as devotion to Allah ◦ duties during fasting ◦ the benefits of fasting to individual Muslims and the Ummah as a whole ◦ Exemptions from fasting ◦ The Night of Power • Ramadan as the month the Qur'an was sent down to mankind • Different experiences for Muslims observing Sawm in Muslim countries and for Muslims living in non-Muslim countries • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	• Surah 2:183–190 (al-Baqarah)
Festivals/special days	• The origin and meaning of: ◦ Eid-ul-Adha: the festival of sacrifice at the end of Hajj. Origins in Ibrahim's sacrifice of an animal instead of his son, Isma'il ◦ Eid-ul-Fitr: celebrated at the end of Ramadan. A public holiday in Muslim countries where gifts and cards are exchanged, and new clothes are brought for children	• Surah 37:102–103 As-Saaffat • Surah 2:196 Al-Baqarah

	◦ Eid-ul-Ghadeer: a Shi'a festival that celebrates the appointment of Ali as successor to Muhammad and Muhammad's last sermon. Presents are given, there are special prayers and celebratory meals ◦ Ashura: a Shi'a festival and it commemorates the martyrdom of the Prophet's grandson Hussayn in 680CE. British Muslims gather in London for a mourning procession • The importance of Eid-ul-Adha, Eid-ul-Fitr, Eid-ul-Ghadeer and Ashura for different groups of Muslims • Issues related to the celebration of festivals and special days for Muslims living in Muslim countries and for Muslims living in non-Muslim countries • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	
Jihad	• The meaning and importance for different groups of Muslims of: ◦ Greater Jihad – the struggle of every Muslim to live according to 'the straight path' ◦ Lesser Jihad – the removal of evil from society with the goal of making the world an abode of peace • The precedence of Greater Jihad over Lesser Jihad • Conditions for the declaration and conduct of Lesser Jihad • The concepts of Munkar and Ma'ruf • Common and divergent views of different Muslim groups about if and when the holy war aspect of Lesser Jihad should be waged • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Muslim groups	• Surah 2:190 (al-Baqarah) • Surah 8:61 (Al-Anfal)

Beliefs and teachings & Practices (J625/03)

Learners will need to be familiar with the expectations laid out on page 6 of the specification.

Beliefs and teachings		
Area of study	Content	Suggested sources of wisdom and authority
	Learners should have studied the following:	(Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate sources of wisdom and authority)
Nature of G-d	• The meaning of the terms G-d as One, Creator, Law-Giver, Judge and Eternal • The significance of the following characteristics for Jews: ◦ All-powerful ◦ All-good ◦ All-knowing ◦ Everywhere ◦ Beyond time and space ◦ Concerned with humanity ◦ Intervening in the world ◦ Transcendent and immanent • Issues related to the nature of G-d, including the problem of evil and suffering • Common and divergent emphases placed on these characteristics by different Jewish groups, including beliefs about the Last Day of the world as Judgement day and the judgements made by G-d on Rosh Hashannah • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Genesis 1:1–2 • Genesis 1:27 • Deuteronomy 6:4–9 • The message contained in the Book of Job • The message contained in the Book of Jonah
The divine presence	• The meaning and origins of the term Shekinah, as referring to the manifest presence of G-d • The significance of Shekinah in Judaism • Association of Shekinah with the feminine aspects of G-d, including the association with the Sefirot (powers/emanations of G-d) and G-d's creative nature • Issues related to the divine presence, including the relationship between God and the prophets	Shekinah is the term used for the presence of God, examples of which in the Torah are: • Exodus 13:20–22 • Exodus 40:35 • Exodus 24:16 • Numbers 9:16

	• Common and divergent emphases placed on Shekinah by different Jewish groups, including understanding the term as synonymous with G-d or as a reference to G-d descending to or dwelling on Earth • Common and divergent emphases place on feminine aspects of G-d by different Jewish groups, including Shekinah as a feminine noun first used in the Talmud • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	
The Covenant at Sinai	• The concept of Covenant • The significance of the Covenant at Sinai (the Ten Commandments) • The role of Moses within Judaism • Issues related to the Convenant at Sinai, including the nature of the promises made by G-d to the Israelites and their significance for modern Judaism • Common and divergent emphases placed on the Covenant at Sinai by different Jewish groups • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Exodus 20:2–14
The Messiah	• The meaning of the term Messiah • The concept of the Messiah • The origins of the term Messiah and the role of Elijah • The importance of the Messiah in Jewish history • The characteristics of the Messah • The importance of the Messianic Age • Issues related to the Messiah, including the different views held amongst religious Jews regarding the nature of the Messiah and the Messianic Age • Common and divergent views, beliefs and attitudes in Judaism about the nature and coming of the Messiah • Common and divergent emphases placed on the concept of Messiah and the Messianic Age by different Jewish groups, including the Messianic Age as an era of global peace and harmony • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Micah 4:1–3 • Genesis 12:1–3 • Isaiah 11:11–12 • Ezekiel 37:24–28

Promised Land	• The concept of the Promised Land: to whom was it promised and in return for what? • The origins of a belief in the Promised Land in the Covenant with Abraham • The significance of the Covenant with Abraham • The role of Abraham and his importance in Judaism • Issues related to the Promised Land, including whether this concept is equally important for all religious Jews • Common and divergent emphases placed on the concept of the Promised Land by different Jewish groups, including attitudes towards the State of Israel • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Micah 4:1–3 • Genesis 12:1–3 • Isaiah 51:3
Key moral principles	• The meaning of the term Mitzvot • The significance of the Mitzvot • Different groupings of Mitzvot including: ◦ Positive commandments (aseh) that say what must be done/followed ◦ Negative commandments (ta'ashe) that say what must be avoided • The meaning of Divine Providence for Jews • The relationship between free will and the Mitzvot • Issues related to key moral principals, including the preservation of human life as a principle that takes precedence over all other commandments (Pikuach Nefesh) • Common and divergent emphases placed on the concept of the Mitzvot by different Jewish groups, including the importance of interpersonal relationships as the principle underlying some Mitzvot • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Exodus 20:2–14 • Deuteronomy 30:19 • Job 42:2 • The message of the Book of Jonah: Divine Providence
Ethical and ritual Mitzvot	• The concepts of ethical and ritual Mitzvot and how they create relationship between Man and G-d and/or man and man • The difference between ethical and ritual Mitzvot • The significance of ethical Mitzvot • Issues related to the Mitzvot, including the existence of different lists of Mitzvot compiled by scholars • Common and divergent emphases placed on the concept of ethical and ritual Mitzvot by different Jewish groups	• Exodus 20:2–14 • Deuteronomy 11:18–21 • Numbers 15:37–41

	• Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	
Sanctity of life	• The meaning and concept of sanctity of life • The significance that Judaism places on the sanctity of human life • The concept and meaning of Pikuach Nefesh (the obligation to save life) • The significance of Pikuach Nefesh in Jewish personal, social and community life • Issues related to the sanctity of life, including what kinds of life are sacred • Common and divergent emphases placed on the concept of the sanctity of life by different Jewish groups, including the difference between human and non-human lives • Common and divergent emphases placed on the concept of Pikuach Nefesh by different Jewish groups, including whether the principle extends to relieving suffering/illness • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Genesis 1:27 • Exodus 20:13 • Leviticus 19:16
Eschatological beliefs and teachings	• The concepts and meaning for Jews of: ◦ The distinction between soul and the body ◦ Resurrection ◦ Judgement ◦ Sheol ◦ Gan Eden ◦ Gehenna • The relationship between the soul and the body • The significance of ideas about the soul and the body for Jewish attitudes towards life after death • The importance of beliefs about life after death • Issues related to eschatological beliefs and teachings, including different ideas about the resurrection of the body • Common and divergent emphases placed on the concept of Judgement by different Jewish groups, including different ideas about the role of judgement in determining the nature of life after death • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Genesis 2:7 • Daniel 12:2–3

Practices		
Area of study	Content	Suggested sources of wisdom and authority
	Learners should have studied the following:	(Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate sources of wisdom and authority)
Worship	• The structure of the synagogue service • The importance of the synagogue, in relation to the following religious features: ◦ Design ◦ Artefacts ◦ Synagogue services ◦ The role of the synagogue within the Jewish community ◦ Worship in the home ◦ The place of worship in the home • The significance of the Ark, the Bimah, the lack of representation of G-d, the Ner Tamid and the Mikveh • The nature and importance of the Torah readings, other readings, prayers and sermons • The connection between the synagogue and the Temple • Issues related to worship and the synagogue, including the length and structure of synagogue services and different uses of Hebrew in the service • Common and divergent emphases placed on the features of a synagogue by different Jewish groups, including separating women and men in an Orthodox synagogue • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Ezekiel 11:16 • Exodus 20:4
Prayer	• The role and importance of prayer in Jewish worship, including the Amidah (the standing prayer) • The role and importance of private prayer for Jews • The importance of: ◦ The three daily periods of prayer ◦ The concept of spontaneous prayer ◦ Recitation of the Shema ◦ Recitation of Grace after meals ◦ Teaching children to pray ◦ The direction faced when praying	• Deuteronomy 6:4

	• Issues related to prayer, including the purpose of prayer • Common and divergent emphases placed on prayer by different Jewish groups, including appropriate attire for prayer • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	
Law	• The form and content of the Tenakh (the Written Law) • The Chumash and the Sefer Torah • The nature of the Talmud (the Oral Law) • The relationship between the Talmud and the Torah, including the ways in which the Talmud is used in relation to the Torah • The use of the Torah in the synagogue • The use of the Tenakh in private worship • The way that the Torah provides structure to the life of a Jew, including the use of the Neviim and Ketuvim in public and private worship • The significance of the use in daily life of the Tenakh and the Talmud • Issues related to the law, including the different views held amongst religious Jews regarding the nature of the Torah and the Talmud • Common and divergent emphases placed on the Tenakh and Talmud by different Jewish groups • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Deuteronomy 10:12–13
Shabbat	• The meaning, origins and significance of Shabbat • The traditions and Mitzvot associated with Shabbat • The meaning and significance of elements of Shabbat, including the preparation, the lighting of candles, the Shabbat meal, Havdalah and the Kiddush • The form of Shabbat services in the synagogue • The form of Shabbat services in the home • Issues related to the observance of Shabbat, including different understandings of what is prohibited by the Mitzvot in the modern world • Common and divergent emphases placed on Shabbat and Shabbat traditions by different Jewish groups, including attitudes towards the literal observance of Shabbat traditions • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Genesis 2:1–3 • Exodus 20:8–11

Festivals	• The origins and importance of Rosh Hashanah, including Teshuva, the Shofar, symbolic foods, the synagogue service and Tashlich • The origins and importance of Yom Kippur, including the connection to Rosh Hashanah, the Book of Life, Kapparah, the rules of Yom Kippur, the importance and nature of fasting, the synagogue services and Neilah • The origins and importance of the Pilgrim Festivals, including the story of the Exodus, the importance of chametz and the Seder meal • The origins and importance of Sukkot, including the building of sukkah and the four species • The origins and importance of Hanukkah • The origins and importance of Pesach • The origins and importance of Shavuot • Issues related to Jewish festivals, including issues with the reconciling of dates in different calendars • Common and divergent emphases placed on festivals by different Jewish groups • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Numbers 29:1 • Micah 7:19 • Leviticus 16:29 • Exodus 12:5–8 • Exodus 12:14–15 • Leviticus 23:15–17 • Leviticus 23:42–43 • Leviticus 23:40
Dietary laws	• The origin and nature of dietary laws • The mitzvot and traditions regarding the slaughter and consumption of animals • The mitzvot and traditions regarding the consumption of poultry, fish, fruit and vegetables • The mitzvot and traditions regarding the consumption of meat and milk together • The importance and impact of dietary laws on Jewish lifestyle • The meaning of the terms Kosher and Terefah • Issues related to the dietary laws, including pikuach nefesh and breaking the laws of kashrut • Common and divergent emphases placed on the dietary laws by different Jewish groups, including the preparation of food by non-Jews • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Leviticus 7:26–27 • Leviticus 11 • Deuteronomy 14:21

Rituals	• The meaning and importance of rites of passage • The form and meaning of Jewish birth ceremonies including: ◦ The welcoming of a baby girl ◦ The connection between Brit Milah and the covenant with Abraham ◦ The circumcision ◦ The roles of the father ◦ Mohel and Sandek ◦ The importance of birth rituals for the community • The form and meaning of Bar/Bat Mitzvah including: ◦ The preparation ◦ The nature of the service ◦ Subsequent preparations ◦ The meaning and nature of Bat Chayil • The meaning and importance of Kiddushin as the betrothal ceremony before the marriage • The nature and importance of: ◦ The Ketubah ◦ The Huppah ◦ The drinking of wine ◦ The ring ◦ The breaking of the glass ◦ The blessings • The meaning and importance of burial rites including: ◦ The nature of burial ◦ The tearing of clothes ◦ The Kaddish • Issues related to rites of passage, including the different attitudes towards the presence and role of women in rites of passage • Common and divergent emphases placed on rites of passage by different Jewish groups, including different attitudes towards Bat Mitzvah • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Jewish groups	• Genesis 17:9–12 • Genesis 2:24
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Buddhism - Beliefs and teachings & Practices (J625/04)

Learners will need to be familiar with the expectations laid out on page 6 of the specification.

Beliefs and teachings		
Area of study	Content	Suggested sources of wisdom and authority
	Learners should have studied the following:	(Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate sources of wisdom and authority)
Buddha and Enlightenment	- The life of Buddha - The early life of Buddha - The Four Sights - Defeat of Mara - Enlightenment - Nibbana - Issues related to the life of Buddha, including the importance of Buddha for Buddhists in the modern world - Common and divergent emphases placed on the life of Buddha by different Buddhist groups - Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	- Anguttara Nikaya (AN) 3.38 - Samyutta Nikaya (SN) 35.199 - Majjhima Nikaya (MN) 36 - Samyutta Nikaya (SN) 56.11
The Dhamma	- The meaning of the term Dhamma (eternal law and Buddha's teachings) - The Dhamma as one of the Three Jewels - The meaning of the term: dependent origination or conditionality - The relationship between dependent origination and the cycle of samsara (rebirth) - The Three Marks of Existence and their meaning: - Dukkha - Impermanence (anicca/anitya) - No fixed self or soul (anatta/anataman) - The significance of the three marks of existence for Buddhists - The 12 links (nidanas) and how one leads to the next over three lifetimes - Issues related to the Dhamma, including the importance of Dhamma for Buddhists in the modern world - Common and divergent emphases placed on the Dhamma by different Buddhist groups, including different definitions of the Dhamma - Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	- Dhammacakkappavattana sutta (Setting the Wheel of the Dhamma in motion) - Dhammapada 35–36 and 334–336 - Nandakovada Sutta 7–10 - The Tibetan Wheel of Life

The First Noble Truth	• The First Noble Truth about the nature of life as suffering (dukkha) • The three different types of suffering: ◦ Painful experiences (dukkha-dukkha) ◦ The changing nature of things (viparinama-dukkha) ◦ All pervasive suffering (sankhara-dukkah) • The nature and significance of the different forms of suffering in Buddhist teaching • Issues related to the First Noble Truth, including the interconnections between different forms of suffering • Common and divergent emphases placed on dukkha by different Buddhist groups, including whether all sentient beings can be liberated from suffering • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	• Dhammacakkappavattana sutta (Setting the Wheel of the Dhamma in motion)
The Second Noble Truth	• The second Noble Truth about the cause of suffering (dukkha) and its forms • The nature of unsatisfactoriness (samudaya) and the way it creates dukkha • The nature of craving (tanha) and the way it creates dukkha • The form and significance in Buddhist teaching of the three poisons/fires (Lobha – attachment, Dosa – aversion/aggression, Moha – ignorance) • The relationship between the three poisons/fires and suffering • Issues related to the Second Noble Truth, including the positive or opposite qualities to the three poisons/fires • Common and divergent emphases placed on the Second Noble Truth by different Buddhist groups, including different ways of understanding ignorance (as confusion or delusion), attachment (as desire, greed or passion) and aversion (as anger or hatred) • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	• Dhammacakkappavattana sutta (Setting the Wheel of the Dhamma in motion) • Dhammapada 334–336

The Third Noble Truth	• The Third Noble Truth about the end of suffering (dukkah) • The meaning of the term nibbana (to extinguish) • Common and divergent ways of understanding nibbana, including as extinguishing the three poisons/fires • The different meanings given to the term Enlightenment • Common and divergent ways of understanding the term Enlightenment • The cessation of craving/desire (tanha/trsna) • Issues related to the Third Noble Truth, including different ways of understanding the relationship between nibbana and the cycle of rebirth • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	• Dhammacakkappavattana sutta (Setting the Wheel of the Dhamma in motion) • Dhammapada 1–2 and 336–337 • Udana 8–1 and 8–3
The Fourth Noble Truth	• The Fourth Noble Truth about the way to eliminate suffering (dukkah) • The elements of the Eightfold Path (magga) • The importance of the Eightfold Path for Buddhists • The grouping of the steps of the Eightfold Path for Buddhists • The elements of the Threefold Way for Buddhists, including ethics (sila), meditation (samadhi) and wisdom (panna) • The importance of the Threefold Way for Buddhists • Issues related to the Fourth Noble Truth, including the relationship between the different elements of the Eightfold Path and the Threefold Way • Common and divergent emphases placed on the ways to eliminate suffering by different Buddhist groups, including different ways of putting the Eightfold path into practice in everyday life • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	• Dhammacakkappavattana sutta (Setting the Wheel of the Dhamma in motion) • Magga-vibhanga Sutta (Samyutta Nikaya 45–8) • Dhamapada 111

The Human Personality	• The concept of the five aggregates (khandas) in Theravada Buddhism • The relationship between the khandas and the concepts of anicca, anatta and dependent origination • The Mahayana concept of sunyata (emptiness) • The Mahayana concept of tathagatagarbha (the potential to become a buddha) • The Mahayana concept of buddha-nature (the inherent buddhahood of all sentient beings) • The relationship between these concepts and the Four Noble Truths • The relationship between these concepts and Buddhist practices • Common and divergent emphases placed on human personality by different Buddhist groups • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	• The Heart Sutta • The Diamond Sutta 3
Human destiny	• The meaning of the terms Arahant/Arhat, Bodhisattvas and Buddhas • The characteristics of Arhants/Arhats, Bodhisattvas and Buddhas • The paths, and the stages on the paths, by which these states are achieved • Buddhist attitudes towards human destiny, including: ◦ Bodhisattva ideals ◦ Buddhahood ◦ Pure Land • Issues related to the Human Destiny, including the distinction between an arhat and a buddha, and the role they play in relation to other sentient beings • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	• Santideva's Bodhicaryavatara 3:6–20 and 8:90–99 • The story of Amida Buddha
Ethical teachings	• The meanings of the following terms: ◦ Kamma/Karma and rebirth/rebecoming (punabbhava) ◦ Compassion (karuna) ◦ Loving kindness (metta/maitri) ◦ Five Precepts (pancha sila)	• Karaniya Metta Sutta (Sutta Nipatta 1:8) • Diamond Sutta 4 and 23

	• The relationship between kamma and the eightfold path, rebirth (samsara) and nibbana • The relationship between the eightfold path and ethical principles • Issues related to ethical teachings, including the importance of balancing compassion with wisdom • Common and divergent emphases placed on ethical teachings by different Buddhist groups, including views about the existence of other perfections/virtues • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	
The application of Buddhist principles in modern life	• The concept of internalisation of virtue • The concepts of skilful and unskilful action • The relationship between skilful and unskilful action, kamma and rebirth • The importance of the Middle Way for Buddhists' moral conduct and daily life • Abstaining from immoral conduct • Issues related to the application of ancient Buddhist principles and the Precepts in relation to modern philosophical and ethical issues • Common and divergent emphases placed on the application of Buddhist principles in modern life by different Buddhist groups • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	• Dhammacakkappavattana sutta (Setting the Wheel of the Dhamma in motion) • Dhammapada 183
Practices		
Area of study	Content	Suggested sources of wisdom and authority
	Learners should have studied the following:	(Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate sources of wisdom and authority)
Worship	• The role and significance of different forms of worship including: ◦ Meditation ◦ Chanting ◦ Puja and devotional ritual ◦ Mantra ◦ Malas	• Dhammapada 273–276

	• The relationship between devotional worship and the aim of ending dukkha • Common and divergent emphases placed on worship by different Buddhist groups, including the importance and meaning of artefacts like malas • The form, focus and aim of the following types of meditation: ◦ Samatha ◦ Maitri or metta bhavana ◦ Vipassana ◦ Zen ◦ Mindfulness ◦ Visualisation • The relationship between meditation and the eightfold path • Common and divergent emphases placed on different types of meditation by different Buddhist groups • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	
Sacred and significant places and spaces for Buddhists	• The importance, features and functions of: ◦ Temples ◦ Gompas and viharas ◦ Shrines ◦ Sites of pilgrimage ◦ Artefacts and offerings ◦ Retreats • The events that take place in different significant places, including Bodhi Gaya and the Deer Park at Sarnath • The meaning and significance of key artefacts and offerings made at different significant places, including the different images of the Buddha and his hand positions (mudras) • The purpose and form of retreats • The importance of undertaking pilgrimages • Common and divergent emphases placed on significant places and spaces by different Buddhist groups, including the role and importance of retreats • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	• Local Buddhist communities and centres

The Sangha	• The meaning of the term Sangha as one of the Three Jewels • The role and importance of: ◦ Monastic sangha ◦ Lay sangha • The Ten Precepts observed by monks and nuns • The ordination of women into the monastic sangha • The common and divergent emphases placed on the sangha by different Buddhist groups, including the rules observed within monasteries • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	• Dhammapada 360–369
Festivals	• The origins, associated stories and customs of the following festivals: ◦ Wesak or Hanamatsuri (Therevada/Mahayana) ◦ Vassa/Rain Retreat (Therevada) ◦ Uposatha Days (Therevada) ◦ Parinirvana day (Mahayana) ◦ Lama Tsong Khapa Day (Tibetan) • The importance of marking different parts of the Buddha's life • The purpose of Vassa and its observance by lay Buddhists today • The purpose of Uposatha days • The purpose of festivals not connected to the Buddha directly, the popularity of these festivals and their place within Buddhism, including the Lama Tsong Khapa day • The influence of local culture on practices associated with Buddhist festivals • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	• Information about the origin and celebration of these events can be found in a wide variety of sources, including: ◦ http://www.thebuddhistsociety.org/ ◦ http://www.religionfacts.com/buddhism/holidays ◦ http://www.buddhanet.net/ ◦ http://www.bbc.co.uk/religion/religions/buddhism/

Attitudes to death and mourning	• Ceremonies and rituals associated with death and mourning: ◦ In Theravada communities ◦ In Tibet: Tibetan Book of the Dead ◦ In Japan: Obon • The significance of death and death customs in Buddhism • Buddhist beliefs about death and rebirth • The influence of local culture on practices associated with Buddhist death and mourning rituals • The importance of death rituals for the person who has died and for their family • The meaning and significance of death rituals within the framework of Buddhist concepts including Kamma, rebirth and the six realms of existence • The significance of the Tibetan Book of the Dead, and the transition period between life and death (Bardo) • The events and significance of Obon • Death and the Buddha's teaching about impermanence • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Buddhist groups	• The Tibetan Book of the Dead • Dhammacakkappavattana sutta (Setting the Wheel of the Dhamma in motion) • Dhammapada 37 and 170–171
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Hinduism

Beliefs and teachings & Practices (J625/05)

Learners will need to be familiar with the expectations laid out on page 6 of the specification.

Beliefs and teachings		
Area of study	Content	Suggested sources of wisdom and authority
	Learners should have studied the following:	(Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate sources of wisdom and authority)
Eternal self	• Atman as the eternal self, the part that is liberated from Samsara • Atman as identical with Brahman • Atman as distinct from Brahman • Common and divergent understandings of the atman and liberation (moksha) by different Hindu groups • Common and divergent understandings of the relationship/connection between atman and Brahman by different Hindu groups • Common and divergent understandings to the approaches of different yogas by different Hindu groups • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	• Bhagavad Gita II 22 • Brihadaranyaka Upanishad III, 7, 15–23 • Mahabharata XII 149 • Dialogue between Uddalaka and Svetaketu (Chandogya Upanishad)
The cycle of birth, life and death	• The meaning of the terms: ◦ Samsara ◦ Maya ◦ Detachment ◦ Moksha • The significance and interconnection of Samsara, Maya, Detachment and Moksha • The relationship between rebirth in samsara and karma • Common and divergent understanding and emphases given to these concepts by different Hindu groups, including the possibility of being jivan mukti (liberated while alive) • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	• Bhagavad Gita II 11–13 • Bhagavad Gita II 27 • Mahabharata XII 240

Karma	• The meaning of the term karma and the role it plays in Hindu life and rebirth • Karma as causality and a form of cosmic justice • Karma as the connection between action and consequence • The state of jivan mukti and its relationship to karma • The relationship of karma with samsara • The effect of positive and negative karma within samsara (parabdha karma) • The creation of karma through choices and actions in the current lifetime (kriyamana karma) and its connection with moral/ethical thinking • Sakam karma (with results in mind) and nishkam karma (desireless/fruitless) and the way these relate to rebirth and liberation • Common and divergent emphases given to karma by different Hindu groups • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	• Bhagavad Gita III, 3–9 • Bhagavad Gita III, 29–30
The nature of reality	• The meanings of the terms: Maya, Loka, Devas and Asuras • The concept of Loka (world/realm/space) and the ways the Lokas are divided • The heavenly realms of the Tri-Murti: Brahma-Loka, Shiva-Loka and Vishnu-Loka/Vaikuntha • The inhabitants of the different realms, including the belief that people are born into different realms as a result of karma • The nature of the material world • The meaning of prakriti, purusha and the trigunas • The role and relationship of prakritim purusha and the trigunas in the creation and constitution of the material world • The cycle of creation and destruction as it applies to the universe, including the roles of the Trimurti and the Mahayuga • Common and divergent teachings and beliefs about worlds and their diverse inhabitants, including Maya, Loka, Devas and Asuras • The nature of reality, including the way gunas interact to determine the nature of things • Common and divergent understandings of cosmology and creation by different Hindu groups, including:	• The Nasadiya Sukta (Rig Veda) • Katha Upanishad III 10–11 • Chandogya Upanishad III 14 • Bhagavad Gita XIII 19–20

	◦ the relationship between the material world and the concept of Maya • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	
Manifestations of the divine	• Different ways of understanding Brahman, with attributes (Saguna Brahman) and without attributes (Nirguna Brahman) • The connection between concepts of Brahman and Hindu practices, including Hindu deities as manifestations of Saguna Brahman • The role and importance of the Trimurti and the Tridevi, including the concept of Shakti and the relationship between male and female deities • The role and importance of Avatara as the incarnation or manifestation of deities in a particular physical form • The role and importance of Murti as the focus of worship and as an expression of an actual presence • The significance of Avatara in different Hindu traditions • Common and divergent emphases placed on manifestations of the divine by different Hindu groups • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	• Smriti and shruti scriptures • Stories of the gods acting within the world • The avatars of Vishnu • The Ramayana • The Bhagavad Gita • Jesus and the Buddha as avatars
Three features of the divine	• The concept of Brahman as the eternal, omnipresent and all-pervading divinity, unlimited, infinite and impersonal (nirguna) and as the personal deity manifested in forms (saguna) • The nature of Brahman as both all-pervading and within the heart of an individual (antaryami) • Brahman as the supreme person (Bhagvan, or Ishvara) living in a spiritual realm • The significance of different ways of understanding Brahman and how this relates to other concepts, including liberation (moksha) • Common and divergent emphases placed on features of the divine by different Hindu groups, including the importance of the relationship to a personal deity • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	• Chandogya Upanishad IV, x, 4–5 • Chandogya Upanishad V, x, 3 • Kena Upanishad I

The four aims of human life (Purusharthas)	• The meaning of the term Dharma, which is dependent on the context in which it is applied • The role and significance of dharma in Hindu life • The relationship between dharma and other concepts such as varna, ashrama, artha, karma and moksha • Sanatana dharma (the eternal dharma) as a name some Hindus give to their religion, including the idea of ancient and universal truths contained within the religion • The relationship between an individual's dharma and the concept of karma • Common and divergent emphases placed on the four aims of human life by different Hindu groups, including different ways of understanding varna and its function in society • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	• Katha Upanishad II 1–2 • Bhagavad Gita II 62–65
Human concerns	• Hindu understanding of the concepts of free will, suffering and virtue, including their relationship to karma and samsara • The meaning and importance of Hindu virtues/ moral duties (yamas), including harmlessness/ non-violence (Ahimsa), compassion (daya), self-control/restraint (dama) and giving (dana) • The relationship between virtues and particular elements of dharma • Common and divergent emphases placed on human concerns by different Hindu groups, including which virtues are identified as of core importance • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	• Mahabharata V 39 • Bhagavad Gita XVI, 1–3 • Bhagavad Gita VIII 8–12

Practices		
Area of study	Content	Suggested sources of wisdom and authority
	Learners should have studied the following:	(Learners will be given credit for referring to any appropriate sources of wisdom and authority)
Ways of living	- The meaning of the four margas: - Jnana yoga - Bhakti yoga - Karma yoga - Astanga or raja yoga - Different Hindu understandings of living a good life and seeking liberation - The approach and practices associated with the different margas - The significance of Varnashra-madharma for individuals and society - The relationship between these ways of living and the concepts of karma and moksha - The role and importance of Hindu approaches to social concerns: - Svadharma (personal duty) - Sewa (service) - Dana (giving) - The common and divergent emphases put on these ways of living by different Hindu groups, including the possibility of following more than one yoga - Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	- Bhagavad Gita II 31 - Bhagavad Gita V 16 - Bhagavad Gita II 47 (karma yoga), IX 26–28 (bhakti yoga), III 29, 38–41 (jnana yoga), VI 5–7 (raja yoga) - The Purusha Sukta (Rig Veda)
Approaching deity	- Different Hindu understandings of the role, forms and importance of the following types of worship: - Havan or homa - Puja - Meditation - Japa - Bhajan or kirtan - Darshan - The nature and importance of sacred places and spaces for Hindu worship: - Temples	- Bhagavad Gita XII 5 - The Bhagavad Gita IX 13–14 - Gayatri Mantra

	• The role and importance of holy people, including gurus and sadhus/sadhvis • The role and importance of sacred plants and animals • The purpose and practice of pilgrimage • Sites of pilgrimage, including varansi and the river Ganges, and the purpose of pilgrimage to different sites • The significance of pilgrimage and practices for Hindus, and their relationship to the different yogas • The importance of darshan and the different forms it can take in relation to murti, holy people and sites of holy places • Common and divergent emphases given to the sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindi groups • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	
Special occasions	• Hindu festivals, their origins, associated deities, stories and customs: ◦ Holi ◦ Navaratri ◦ Diwali ◦ Maha Shivratri ◦ Ganesh Chaturthi ◦ Raksha Bandhan • Different Hindu attitudes to these festivals, their meaning and importance. • Why Ganesh Chaturthi is so widely celebrated • Common and divergent emphases placed on festivals by different Hindu groups, including their popularity and importance across different branches of Hinduism • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	Information about the origin and celebration of these events can be found in a wide variety of sources, including: • http://hinduonline.co/hinduCulture.html • http://www.bbc.co.uk/schools/religion/hinduism/index.shtml • http://hinduism.about.com

Ethical Concerns	• Hindu attitudes to, and beliefs and teachings about, the environment and the natural world, including: ◦ The treatment of animals ◦ The treatment of the environment • Hinduism and social issues: ◦ Social responsibility ◦ Social inclusion ◦ Womens rights • The ways Hindu attitudes, beliefs and teachings are put into practice through charitable projects, including: ◦ Hinduism and the Assisi Declarations on nature (1986) ◦ The protection of sacred cows through goshallas, the Ahimsa Foundation for Cattle Protection ◦ Sewa International (Sewa UK) • Different interpretations and emphases given to sources of wisdom and authority by different Hindu groups	• The Purusha Sukta (Rig Veda) • The Bhagavad Gita • The work and example of Gandhi • Karma and the cycle of samsara • Yamas (virtues) especially daya (compassion), dama (restraint) and kshama (patience/tolerance) • Mahabharata XVIII 113 8 • Mahabharata III 29 • Myths and stories about the deities associated with ethical concerns
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